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On his third attempt of the competition, even as high-speed TV cameras strained to frame the still-soaring fluorescent green projectile that he had flung into the black night of Doha, Neeraj Chopra threw his arms up, index fingers pointing to the sky. He didn't need to wait to see where his javelin would land on the turf of the Suheim bin Hamad Stadium many, many, many metres away. He has spoken before of knowing, the moment the spear leaves his hand, whether he's made a good throw — whether the job's done or not.

His arms were aloft in the final of the Tokyo Olympics, where he won a milestone gold. They were raised in victory at the World Championships in Budapest. They telegraphed his triumph at the Asian Games and Commonwealth Games. On the night of May 16 at the Doha Diamond League, they did so once more, as the 27-year-old entered the history books.

Barrier breached

90.23m.

The digital board at the other end of the ground flashed just how far his javelin had travelled. It was a new national record (not that surprising anymore, considering he's bettered it half a dozen times since first setting it nine years ago) and the world lead. But more than that, it placed him in one of the most exclusive groups in world athletics — the 90m club in men's javelin throw.

Ever since the implement was redesigned in 1986 — nearly four decades ago — Neeraj is the 26th man to know what it's like to throw a spear that far. Let's put the exclusivity of the 90m barrier in perspective: 183 runners have broken the 10-second mark in the 100m — perhaps the most well-known informal athletics standard. The equivalent of the 90m club in the 100m would be a tiny group of sprinters clocking 9.85 seconds or faster.

Despite the magnitude of the accomplishment, the overwhelming emotion

on the face of the 27-year-old wasn't ecstasy or joy. It seemed to be relief. There was just a hint of a smile as he accepted handshakes from the rest of the field. Then, it was back to business once again.

A monkey off his back

At every Press conference and interview he's attended over the past seven years, including in Doha last week, Neeraj would be asked some variation of: "When will you cross 90m?"

Each time, he would respond with some permutation of: "It's a target and I'm getting close, but I'm not going to lose sleep over it."

It's possible that, with time, the number had lost some of its hold over Neeraj. He'd often make the fundamentally sound point that staying consistent and winning medals was far more important than chasing what was essentially an arbitrary number — much like the 10-second barrier in the 100m. His former coach Klaus Bartonietz had backed him on this as well.

"What's so special about 90m?" Klaus had once asked a reporter. Its significance, he'd explain, came only because we measure distances in metres, and that the base of 10 is used in mathematical applications so people tend to find it easier quantifying things in multiples of that number. "If we were measuring using feet, then we'd wonder what's so special about 295.276 feet (the equivalent of 90m)," he'd say.

Yet, as much as he denied it mattered to him, it was important for Neeraj to reach this mark — if only to prove to himself that he could hit it when it mattered most. In Paris, at the Olympic Games, Neeraj had once again come tantalisingly close with a throw of 89.45m. There, though, Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem produced a mammoth 92.97m to storm to the gold.

This time too, in Doha, despite Neeraj's milestone performance, he was pipped to the win by Germany's Julian Weber, who threw a personal best 91.06m with his final attempt of the competition. Add Anderson Peters (who came third in Doha) — someone who has thrown over 90m at five separate competitions, including once late last season — to the mix,

« I don't know about me, but I think the burden of Indians (who were waiting for me to breach 90m) would have gone down! This is a long season and we have the World Championships in September. *Abhi main khul ke maarunga* (now I'm going to throw freely) »